

From High AHT to Root Cause: Idle Time

Operational Excellence Program · APAC Content Operations

AHT BASELINE	AHT RESULT	IDLE RATE BASELINE	IDLE RATE RESULT
9.9 min	3.1 min	9.5%	0.0%

01 WHAT WAS BROKEN

Appeals Average Handling Time (AHT) was running at 9.9 minutes against a much lower target, dragging down throughput across the queue. The initial assumption was that tasks themselves were getting harder or slower to review, but that didn't hold up when we looked closer at where the time was actually going.

02 THE DEEP DIVE: ROOT CAUSE WAS IDLE TIME, NOT TASK DIFFICULTY

Breaking AHT down by active working time versus non-active time on the same open session revealed the real driver: Idle Rate was sitting at 9.5%. In this context, idle time is the portion of a session where the task stays open and tracked, but the moderator isn't actively working it, the screen is simply left as-is rather than being reviewed. Because idle time is counted inside the session's total handling time, high idle time inflates AHT directly, even though the moderator's actual review effort per task hadn't changed.

Further investigation into the idle-flagged sessions surfaced why this was happening:

- Moderators leaving a task open and stepping away without pausing or closing the session.
- Assisting colleagues or handling side conversations while a task remained open in the background.
- Sessions left idle while waiting on an SME decision, with no prompt to pause the timer.
- No real-time visibility, idle time was only surfaced in next-week reporting, too late to intervene.

03 WHAT I CHANGED

Because idle time was the actual lever behind AHT, the fix targeted idle behavior directly rather than task-level efficiency:

ACTION	DESCRIPTION	OWNER
Built idle tracker	Weekly report isolating idle time within each session, broken down by specialist and cause	PM (me)
Behavior coaching	1:1 coaching with repeat offenders on pausing sessions instead of leaving tasks open idle	Team Leads
SME escalation SLA	Introduced a 15-minute response SLA for SME escalations so sessions weren't left idle awaiting a decision	PM + SME Lead
Weekly visibility	Moved idle reporting from monthly to weekly so idle sessions were caught on the week after	PM (me)

04 WHAT HAPPENED

Idle Rate declined steadily over six weeks as coaching took hold and the SME SLA removed the largest structural cause of idle sessions, closing at 0.0% and holding there through the following reporting cycle. Because idle time had been the actual driver of AHT, Appeals AHT fell in direct responses, from 9.9 to 3.1 minutes over the same period, without any change to how thoroughly each task was reviewed.

Key takeaway: the AHT problem and the idle rate problem were the same problem. Isolating idle time from active task time was what made the root cause visible, and fixing it, not asking moderators to work faster, was what actually moved AHT.

Note: this document has been recreated with generic detail for portfolio purposes. It reflects the structure and approach of an actual improvement initiative I led; the supporting weekly trackers (linked alongside this case study) use sanitized sample data.